

repost.

KEEP IT LIT · a gamified social network where attention is survival

Every post is a dying ember. It vanishes unless people care enough to keep it alive, so engagement stops being a vanity score and becomes the thing that decides what survives.

The idea in one breath

Most social platforms make engagement an additive vanity metric. Likes pile up and nothing is ever at stake. Repost inverts that. A post arrives with a lifespan and visibly decays toward deletion. A repost adds time and keeps it alive; neglect lets it die. Saving something becomes a vote that it deserves to exist. The result is a feed with real stakes, built around one legible metaphor: a shared hearth the community keeps lit.

WHY IT MATTERS NOW

People are tired of sterile, algorithmically-curated feeds built to squeeze attention. They keep reaching for novelty and play. Repost offers stakes and gamification without the manipulative dark patterns. It gives people the antidote instead of repackaging the same machine.

How the core loop works

- **Posts decay.** Each post has a lifespan and a visible lifeline ticking toward deletion.
- **Reposts are life support.** A repost adds time on a diminishing curve, so people can sustain a post without ever making it immortal.
- **Different people drive the clock.** How many distinct people keep something alive sets its time. One superfan, or a small pact, cannot carry a post alone.
- **Additions become living branches.** A repost that adds content grows a sub-post with its own life that channels life back up to the original. The post becomes a living record rather than a copy chain.
- **Everything still dies.** Even the most-loved post burns down in the end. Mortality is the point. It makes saving mean something.

The depth beneath the loop

The loop alone is the product. Underneath sits a staged roadmap of systems, each reinforcing the same metaphor: a grade ladder (Spark to Inferno) that lifts a post's ceiling as it earns broad support; standing, where a post's strongest contributors raise its rank the way a party raises its leader; an ember economy where every action costs a regenerating resource, so spam limits itself and contributing beats broadcasting; earned titles that carry real, lasting benefits; and an opt-in adversarial layer where posts clash for grade. A clash wounds but never kills outright, so death always comes from neglect.

THE COLD-START CURE (the survival mechanic)

A decay feed has one failure mode: the empty room. Too few people, and everything dies. Repost answers this in the mechanic itself. When the app is sparse, a density-driven regime keeps decay gentle so posts persist, and it caps how large they can grow. As the community grows, decay hardens and ceilings rise. The app brands its first users as founders ('First Bearer of the Flame') with permanent, unforgeable status, and a slew cap keeps even a sudden surge of users from collapsing the feed.

Where it is today

- **Working interactive prototype.** A self-contained browser simulation of the full mechanic set: decay, saves, branches, grades, economy, and the density regime.
- **Tested design, no backend yet.** Running the model across simulated growth curves shows the mechanics hold and stay bounded.
- **Clear build path.** Ship a stripped first release (the decay-and-save loop and a thin stats layer) on a FastAPI and PostgreSQL stack, into one dense niche community, to prove retention before adding depth.

How it would make money

Revenue waits until year two. Premature monetization kills more social apps than weak mechanics do. The first job is proving people come back to save things. Once retention holds, the grade and title systems give a clean surface for cosmetic and premium personalization, which are high-margin digital goods with near-zero marginal cost. We never sell life or grade outright, since that reintroduces the pay-to-win manipulation the product exists to reject.

Anticipated questions and answers

Grouped by who is most likely to ask. Figures marked *illustrative* are placeholders, not commitments. Replace them with real numbers before any external use.

1 • The investment partner

venture or angel, focused on market, differentiation, moat, and the path to scale

Q What problem are you solving, and is it big enough?

A Engagement fatigue on feeds that feel manipulative and hollow. The market is all of social, and winning a large share is not the goal. A differentiated mechanic that captures one passionate niche and expands from there is the pattern every breakout social app followed.

Q What is defensible here, and what is the moat?

A Mechanics get copied, so the mechanic is not the moat. The defensibility is the community, the accumulated provenance where every post records who valued what and when, and founder status nobody can manufacture later. A clone launches into an empty room with no history and no founders.

Q Isn't this just ephemeral messaging, Snapchat with extra steps?

A Snapchat's disappearing is about privacy and intimacy. Repost's is about collective value signaling. Content survives only because people chose to keep it, and that choice is public, lasting, and status-bearing. The mechanic creates stakes and a shared thing to rally around. Disappearing photos never did that.

Q Why now, and why hasn't this existed?

A Appetite for play over sterility runs high right now, and the cost of running a real-time social backend has collapsed. The hard design problem, surviving the empty room, is now solvable with the density regime that earlier ephemeral apps never had.

Q What's the traction plan, and what milestone proves it?

A Launch narrow and dense: one fandom or community where a few hundred people share a room and posts get saved. One milestone matters, retention. Do people come back to keep things alive. If yes at small scale, depth and breadth follow. If no, even in a warm full room, you learned that cheaply.

Q Biggest risk you'd flag yourself?

A Cold start. A decay feed with too few users feels like a morgue. Three decisions target that phase: gentle early decay, founder rewards, and a niche launch. The second risk is novelty fatigue, which is why a real system sits under the game, scarcity tracked to engagement, to keep it meaningful after the shine fades.

Q What does an exit look like?

A A platform wanting a young, engaged graph buys it. That path has clear precedent, and it sits downstream of traction. You never design for it. You optimize for retention, and the rest follows or it doesn't.

2 · Finance and financial due diligence

CFO or financial reviewer, focused on unit economics, burn, and the cost curve

Q What does it cost to run at small scale?

A Very little. The first release runs on one low-cost VPS (low tens of dollars a month, *illustrative*) with PostgreSQL and a FastAPI backend. The decay model costs almost nothing to compute, a few fields and a filtered query, so infrastructure scales gently with users.

Q What is the cost structure as it grows?

A The main costs are infrastructure (compute, storage, media hosting, real-time delivery) and, later, trust-and-safety moderation. Both scale with engaged users rather than lurkers, which helps. There is no costly recommendation engine to run early, since the feed is mechanic-driven rather than ML-driven.

Q What's the burn and runway picture?

A Before revenue, burn is mostly founder time plus minor hosting. A seed round would fund a small team, moderation tooling, and growth experiments. Burn and runway figures stay *illustrative* until you set a real budget and salary plan.

Q When does revenue arrive, and what are the unit economics?

A Revenue waits until retention holds. The model layers cosmetic and premium personalization on the grade and title systems, high-margin digital goods with near-zero marginal cost. Selling in-app advantage stays off the table by design. LTV and CAC stay *illustrative* before launch and mean something only once retention curves exist.

Q How sensitive is the model to a slow start?

A Costs stay low, since hosting is cheap and follows load, and revenue can wait. The financial risk is not a high burn rate. It is spending time before retention is proven, so the plan gates spend on that one signal.

3 · The bank (loan underwriting)

lender, focused on repayment certainty, cash flow, and collateral

Q Is a pre-revenue software startup a candidate for a conventional business loan?

A Honestly, rarely on its own merits. Banks underwrite repayment from predictable cash flow or collateral, and a pre-revenue app has neither. Bank financing fits after revenue and recurring cash flow exist, or through early-stage instruments: an SBA-style program, a line secured by other assets, or a personal guarantee. A standard commercial term loan does not fit yet.

Q What collateral could back a facility?

A Early on, a personal guarantee and any tangible assets. The intellectual property and codebase carry little liquidation value to a lender. That is why equity or revenue-based financing fits a venture like this better than debt until cash flow exists.

Q How would repayment be serviced?

A Only once subscription and cosmetic revenue is live and recurring. Asking a bank to model repayment from speculative future revenue will not fly. The real ask comes later, sized to demonstrated monthly recurring revenue.

Q What would make this bankable?

A Retention that converts to recurring revenue, a few quarters of statements, and a debt-service-coverage ratio the lender can verify. Until then the right capital is risk capital, and a bank conversation is premature. Said plainly so no one wastes their time.

4 · The potential end user

the person deciding whether to open it twice

Q What is this, in plain terms?

A A feed where the stuff you post disappears unless people care enough to keep it alive. Reposting something is how you save it. The things worth keeping stick around because a community chose them, together.

Q So my posts just vanish? Why would I want that?

A Because it makes what survives mean something. Nothing rots in an endless archive, and a post that lives is one people fought to keep. You also see who saved yours and when, a small real record of who showed up for you.

Q Why is this more fun than what I already use?

A There are stakes. Watching something good tick toward the edge and catching it at the last second beats a passive scroll. Keeping a corner of the app alive with your friends turns a feed into something you tend together.

Q Will it get toxic or full of pile-ons?

A The design fights that. The competitive layer is opt-in, pits posts against posts rather than people against people, and cannot target someone's whole account. The default is cooperative: you keep things alive instead of tearing them down.

Q What happens to my data and the things that die?

A Posts nobody keeps alive get deleted, by design. That is the opposite of a platform that hoards everything forever. What stays is the record of contributions people chose to make.

5 · Adversarial questions

the hard ones a skeptic, competitor, or careful diligence will press on

Q This is a gimmick. Won't the novelty wear off in three weeks?

A That is the real risk for any novel-mechanic app, and more mechanics will not fix it. Under the game sits a system that models something true: attention is scarce, so scarcity tracks engagement. Add the habit pull of a social graph and posts you saved pinging you as they die again. A system that mirrors reality outlasts a trick.

Q It dies in the empty room. A decay feed with no users is a graveyard.

A Agreed, it is the main threat, and the design answers it in the mechanic. The density regime makes an early, sparse app decay gently so posts persist. Founder status rewards the first users for tolerating thinness. Launch goes into one dense community, never broad. Density before breadth is the whole go-to-market.

Q The clash layer contradicts your 'antidote to adversarial feeds' pitch.

A Fair tension, and that is why the clash layer is opt-in and held back from the core launch. The cooperative keep-it-alive loop is the heart. Competition is a later, contained option for the people who want it, fenced with post-versus-post rules and anti-harassment guards. If it ever undermines the thesis, it gets cut.

Q What stops bots, brigading, and gaming the save mechanic?

A The economics. Distinct people drive life, with steep diminishing returns on repeat support, so a bot farm or a small pact cannot sustain a post. Every action costs a regenerating resource, so spam limits itself. A determined crowd can still sustain content, which is why a moderation layer and a clear policy sit on top from day one.

Q How do you handle harmful content, harassment, and legal safety duties?

A The same way any platform must: enforceable terms, a content policy, reporting and moderation tooling, and handling of illegal material before scale rather than after. The mechanic exempts the platform from none of this. Child-safety and abuse handling are baseline requirements, not options.

Q Isn't engineered urgency just another dark pattern, manufactured anxiety?

A The urgency here is honest and shared, not a manufactured personal FOMO loop. Posts decay on transparent rules anyone can read, and no hidden model optimizes your time on app. If a feature starts manufacturing compulsion instead of meaning, it fails the product's own test and comes out.

Q What's defensible? A bigger company copies this in a weekend.

A They can copy the timer in a weekend. They cannot copy a community, its history, or its founders. The graph and the belonging defend a social product, not the mechanic. A fast follower still has to win the cold-start fight from zero, with none of the provenance that makes the original feel alive.

Q It's a solo, self-taught founder with a prototype and no users. Why back this?

A Because the proof is in the build: a complete, coherent system designed and stress-tested end to end, with the hardest problem, cold start, handled in the design rather than waved away. The honest framing is a small but real chance of breakout, a strong chance of a defensible niche, and a working, original social product either way.

Repost (working title) · concept and mechanics overview · prepared as a discussion document. Illustrative figures are placeholders pending a real financial model. Accompanied by an interactive prototype.